

Rushdie & Roy: guided exercises

Private practice for Hana and Aiden

Use this version before the plain worksheet. Each page explains the literary move, shows one model answer, and then leaves space for a new answer. The aim is to borrow the method, not the exact words.

Rule: use normal English words. Do not copy the source fragment or the model answer.

1. Rushdie: pressure from the past

"handcuffed to history"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English

This does not mean someone is literally in handcuffs. It means the past has power over the person. Family history, reputation, old promises or old mistakes can feel as if they are holding the character's wrists.

The task

Make an invisible pressure feel physical. Do not write only 'he felt trapped'. Show what is trapping him.

Model answer

Mina walked into school with her father's unfinished promise dragging at her ankles.

Why it works

The sentence turns a promise into something heavy that follows the body. We can feel the pressure before we know the whole story.

Now you try

Write one sentence about a child who feels trapped by family expectation, a promise, a rumour or an old mistake.

2. Rushdie: a whole world inside one person

"swallow a world"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English	The phrase suggests that one person can contain a huge amount: memories, places, languages, loyalties, fears and secrets. To understand the person, you almost have to enter the world inside them.
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The task	Show that a character is complicated by giving them a hidden inner world.
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Model answer	To understand Leila, you had to cross the city she carried inside: the bakery smell, the shouting buses, the sea wind she missed.
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Why it works	The answer avoids saying 'Leila was complicated'. It gives details that make her inner life visible.
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Now you try

Write three sentences beginning with: To understand him/her, you had to...

3. Rushdie: make an abstract force physical

Plain English

Rushdie often makes large ideas feel bodily. Instead of leaving words like guilt, pride or history floating in the air, he gives them weight, force and action.

The task

Choose one abstract noun and make it do something physical to a character.

Model answer

Guilt pressed its thumb into Josh's throat whenever the teacher asked who had broken the window.

Why it works

Guilt becomes a hand. The pressure in the throat also shows why Josh cannot speak easily.

Now you try

Write four sentences. Use one of these nouns: guilt, pride, jealousy, ambition, homesickness, duty.

4. Roy: weather with a mood

"hot, brooding month"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	A month cannot literally brood. Roy gives the weather a human mood, so the place feels tense before anything happens.
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The task	Let the weather suggest emotion before the characters explain anything.
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Model answer	The afternoon was airless and watchful; even the curtains seemed to be waiting for the argument.
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Why it works	The sentence makes the room feel tense without saying 'everyone was tense'. The weather prepares the reader.
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Now you try

Describe the weather before an exam, an argument or a secret being revealed.

5. Roy: a body-shaped adverb

"fatly baffled in the sun"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	The adverb makes confusion look physical. The point is not to invent strange words. The point is to choose a normal adverb that changes the body's shape or posture.
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The task	Show a feeling through how the character stands, moves or speaks.
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Model answer	He stood stiffly cheerful in the doorway, smiling too hard at everyone.
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Why it works	The word 'stiffly' shows the smile is not relaxed. The reader senses discomfort without being told exactly what he feels.
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Now you try

Write four sentences using normal adverbs such as stiffly, heavily, sharply, awkwardly, proudly, slowly or weakly.

6. Roy: setting as warning

Plain English	Roy often lets the place know something before the people say it. A room, a window, a fan or a glass can make the scene feel uneasy.
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The task	Describe a place five minutes before bad news arrives. Do not mention the bad news yet.
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Model answer	The kitchen fan clicked above the table. A glass of water trembled each time the washing machine turned, though nobody touched it.
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Why it works	The objects are ordinary, but they feel slightly wrong. The reader expects something to happen.
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Now you try

Write a short room description before bad news, an apology or a secret.

7. Mixed drill: pressure and atmosphere

Plain English This exercise combines the two moves. First make the setting carry emotion. Then make an invisible pressure act on the character.

The task Write two sentences: one atmosphere sentence, then one pressure metaphor.

Model answer The corridor smelled of raincoats and metal radiators, and the lights buzzed as if they knew. Adam's promise to his mother sat in his pocket like a stone.

Why it works The first sentence creates atmosphere. The second gives pressure a physical object, a stone in the pocket.

Now you try

Write your own two-sentence version. Do not copy the model.

8. Final writing challenge

Plain English For a longer answer, do not try to sound clever in every sentence. Use one strong atmosphere sentence and one strong pressure metaphor, then let the scene move.

The task Choose one: new school with a family secret, silent family dinner, or meeting someone who seems to carry another place inside them.

Model answer The dining room was too warm, and the windows had gone black with evening. Sami's lie sat between the plates, small and hard, waiting for someone to pick it up.

Why it works The room creates tension first. The lie becomes a hard object on the table. The image is simple enough to understand but strong enough to remember.

Now you try

Write the opening six to eight lines of your chosen scene.
